The First Three Days After Mom Comes Home: What to Organize First

Three moves, in order, and what can wait.

Mom is home and the discharge papers are on the counter. Everyone is asking what happens now, and nobody is sure where to start.

Start here. Three things, in this order.

1 Put the paperwork in one place

Find the written discharge instructions, the summary of her current health and the drug list, and put them in one folder with the phone numbers you were given. If one of them is missing, call and ask for it. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Everything else this week refers back to these papers, and everyone you talk to will ask for them.

2 Write down what she does today

For three days, note what Mom does on her own and what she needs a hand with: bathing, dressing, using the bathroom, stairs, meals. Write down today's abilities, not the ones from before the hospital. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The plan was made in the hospital. The next conversation needs to know what home looks like.

3 List your questions, and who each one goes to

Write every question down as it comes up. Keep the medication questions on their own list for the pharmacist or the prescriber, and change nothing until you've asked. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A written question gets asked. An unwritten one gets remembered in the parking lot.

What can wait a week

- Whether she needs more care than she has now, or a different kind.
- Where she should live.
- Who in the family does what in the long run.
- What it all means. That takes an assessment, and your three days of notes are what make it a good one.

What doesn't wait

If the discharge papers told you to watch for something and you see it, call the number you were given. Medicare's checklist tells families to ask which complications to watch for and what to do about them. If nobody gave you that answer, call and ask for it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't interpret the discharge papers or decide anything about Mom's care. It puts the first three days in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've got the papers together, three days of notes and a list of questions. The care interview takes it from there: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The paperwork to gather, the everyday activities to note and the advice to ask about complications follow Medicare's discharge checklist. The advice not to change medications without asking follows the National Institute on Aging. The order is ours.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. National Institute on Aging, Taking Medicines Safely as You Age

---

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.